

Session 12: The Baptism of Jesus

Key Takeaways

- Through Hebrew Bible references, Matthew places Jesus in the position of both Yahweh and Yahweh's servant.
- The voice of the Father affirms Jesus' identity as David's son, the messianic king; Abraham's son, the seed of promise; and Yahweh's suffering servant as described by Isaiah.
- Jesus fills-full righteousness by going beyond what is strictly required and standing in the gap for vulnerable humanity. He does this by walking through the waters of death with us.

Matthew 3:1-17

¹ Now, in those days **ioannes** **the immerser** arrived,
announcing in **the wilderness** of **loudaia** ,
² saying,
b " **Change direction** !
A Because **the kingdom of the skies** has come near!"
³ For **this is what was spoken through Esaias the prophet**, saying,
a' "A voice calling in **the wilderness**,
prepare the way of **the Lord** ,
make straight his paths."

B ⁴ Now, **ioannes** himself had his clothing from the hair of camels,
and an animal-skin belt was around his waist,
and his food was grasshoppers and wild honey.

A' ⁵ Then, there came out to him Hierosoluma,
and all **loudaia**
and all the surrounding region of **the lordanes**,
⁶ and they were **immersed** in **the lordanes river** by him,
while **confessing their moral failures** .

7 And seeing many of the Pharisaions and Saddoukaions coming out to his **immersion**, he said to them,

“You **seed** of snakes !

Who directed you to flee from **the coming anger** ?!

8 So then, **produce fruit** worthy of a **change-of-direction** ,

9 and don’t suppose you can say to yourselves,

‘We have **Abra’am** as a **father**.’

For I tell you that God is able to raise up from these stones **children** for Abra’am !

10 For **the axe** is already laid at the root of the trees!

For every **tree** that does not **produce good fruit** will be cut down, and into the **fire** it will be tossed!

11 For I **immerse** y’all in **water** for a **change-of-direction** ,

but the one coming after me is more strong than me, whose sandal I am not worthy to carry.

He will **immerse** you with the **Holy Spirit** and **fire** ,

12 whose **threshing-fork** is in his hand,

and he will clear out his threshing floor,

and he will gather his **wheat** into the store-house,

but the grain-husks he will **burn** with **unextinguishable fire** .”

13 Then Iesous arrived from Galilaias at **the lordanes**, to **Ioannes**, to be **immersed** by him,

14 but **Ioannes** **prevented him**, saying,

a “I need to be **immersed** by you, and you would come to me?!”

15 But responding Iesous said to him,

b “**Allow** it now!

For this is what’s appropriate for us, in order to **fill-full** all doing-right.”

a’ **Then he allowed him.**

16 And, after being **immersed**, Iesous immediate came up from **the water**,

A' and look, **the skies** were opened for him,
and he saw the **spirit of God** coming down like a dove,
and coming upon him,
17 and look, a voice from **the skies** was speaking,
"This is **my son** ,
the beloved one,
in him I have delight."

Matthew 3:1-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

A 3:1 Now, in those days **loannes** **the immerser** arrived,
announcing in **the wilderness** of **loudaia** ,

B 2 saying,
" **Change direction** !
Because **the kingdom of the skies** has come near!"

A' 3 For **this is what was spoken through Esaias the prophet**, saying,
"A voice calling in **the wilderness**,
prepare the way of **the Lord** ,
make straight his paths."

4 Now, **loannes** himself had his clothing from the hair of camels,
and an animal-skin belt was around his waist,
and his food was grasshoppers and wild honey.

5 Then, there came out to him Hierosoluma,
and all **loudaia**
and all the surrounding region of **the lordanes**,
6 and they were **immersed** in **the lordanes river** by him,
while **confessing their moral failures** .

Matthew 3:1-6. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

⁷ And seeing many of the Pharisaions and Saddoukaions coming out to his **immersion**,
he said to them,

A "You **seed** of snakes !
Who directed you to flee from **the coming anger** ?!

⁸ So then, **produce fruit** worthy of a **change-of-direction**,

⁹ and don't suppose you can say to yourselves,

B 'We have **Abra'am** as a **father**.'
For I tell you that God is able to raise up from these stones **children** for **Abra'am** !

¹⁰ For **the axe** is already laid at the root of the trees!

A' For every **tree** that does not **produce good fruit** will be cut down,
and into the **fire** it will be tossed!

¹¹ For I **immerse** y'all in **water** for a **change-of-direction**,
but the one coming after me is more strong than me,
whose sandal I am not worthy to carry.
He will **immerse** you with the **holy spirit** and **fire**,

¹² whose **threshing-fork** is in his hand,
and he will clear out his threshing floor,
and he will gather his **wheat** into the store-house,
but the grain-husks he will **burn** with **unextinguishable fire**."

Matthew 3:7-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

John the Messenger and Moses and Elijah

Luke's gospel account provides us with the only biographical information we have about John in the New Testament: He is from a priestly lineage, he was dedicated as a Nazirite from birth, and he was a relative of Jesus (Luke simply mentions that Mary and Elizabeth were "relatives" [Grk. συγγενεις], not necessarily cousins, see [Luke 1:36](#)).

Matthew's portrait of John's identity makes more usage of hyperlinks from the Scriptures, all of them converging on a related set of texts and themes. [Isaiah 40](#) is the springboard text, but it is linked to many others that explain Matthew's introduction to John.

Isaiah 40:1-5 NASB

¹ "Comfort, O comfort my people," says your God.

² "Speak kindly to Jerusalem;
and call out to her, that her warfare has ended,
that her iniquity has been removed,
that she has received of the LORD's hand
double for all her sins."

³ **A voice is calling,**

**"In the wilderness clear the way for Yahweh;
make smooth a highway** in the desert for our God.

⁴ Let every valley be lifted up,
and every mountain and hill be made low;
and let the rough ground become a plain,
and the rugged terrain a broad valley;

⁵ then the glory of Yahweh will be revealed,
and all flesh will see it together;
for the mouth of the LORD has spoken."

Malachi 3:1-3 NASB

¹ "Behold, I am going to send **my messenger**,
and **he will prepare the way before me**.
And the LORD, whom you seek,
he will suddenly come to his temple;
and the messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight, behold, he is coming,"
says the LORD of hosts.

² "But **who can endure the day of his coming?**
And who can stand when he appears?
For **he is like a refiner's fire** and like fullers' soap.

³ He will sit as a smelter and purifier of silver,
and he will purify **the sons of Levi** and refine them like gold and silver,
so that they may present to the LORD offerings in righteousness."

Malachi 4:4-6 NASB

⁴ "Remember the law of Moses my servant, even the statutes and ordinances which I commanded him in Horeb for all Israel.

⁵ Behold, I am going to send you **Elijah the prophet** before **the coming of the great and terrible day of the LORD**.

⁶ **He will change the direction/restore (Heb. *shuv* / שׁוּב) the hearts** of the fathers to their children and the hearts of the children to their fathers, so that I will not come and smite the land with a curse."

2 Kings 1:7-8 NASB

⁷ He said to them, "What kind of man was he who came up to meet you and spoke these words to you?"

⁸ They answered him, "He was **a hairy man with a leather belt bound about his loins.**" And he said, "It is Elijah the Tishbite."

Matthew portrays John as the messenger anticipated by Isaiah who will announce the coming of Yahweh to restore his captive people.

This opening paragraph of Isaiah 40 (the first scroll of the Prophets) is closely linked to the final paragraph of Malachi (the final unit of the last scroll of the Prophets), where the same event is anticipated. But in Malachi 4, the identity of the voice is specified to be "Elijah the prophet." Malachi lived centuries after Elijah the Tishbite died, and so it's clear that Malachi is using Elijah as a symbol for the "prophet like Moses" who Moses himself anticipated in the Torah (see Deut. 18:15-17).

Matthew himself makes this identification with Elijah explicit later in the Gospel (see Matt. 11:10, 14; 17:11-13).

Just as Moses and Elijah confronted a faithless generation of Israel with the arrival of God as Israel's divine King, so now John is preparing Israel for the Lord's arrival once more.

The Dead Sea Scrolls Connection

"Rule of the Community (1QS Column 8:1)

1 In the Community council (there shall be) twelve men and three priests, perfect in everything that has been revealed from all

2 the law to implement truth, justice, judgment, compassionate love and unassuming behaviour of one to another,

3 to preserve faithfulness in the land with firm purpose and **repentant spirit** in order to atone for sin by doing justice

4 and undergoing trials, and to walk with everyone in the measure of the truth and the regulation of the time.

When these things exist in Israel

5 the Community council shall be founded on truth, Blank to be an everlasting plantation, a holy house for Israel and the foundation of the holy of

6 holies for Aaron, true witnesses for the judgment and chosen by the will (of God) to atone for the land and to render

7 the wicked their retribution. Blank This (the Community) is the tested rampart, the precious cornerstone that does not Blank

8 /whose foundations/ shake or tremble from their place. Blank (It will be) the most holy dwelling

9 for Aaron with eternal knowledge of the covenant of justice and in order to offer a pleasant /aroma/; and it will be a house of perfection and truth in Israel

10 in order to establish {/.../} a covenant in compliance with the everlasting decrees. /And these will be accepted in order to atone for the land and to decide the judgment of the wickedness {in perfect behaviour} and there will be no iniquity/. **When these have been established in the foundation of the**

Community for two full years in perfect behaviour

11 **/they will be segregated/ (like) holy ones in the midst of the council of the men of the Community.** And every matter hidden from Israel but which has been found out by

12 the Interpreter, he should not keep hidden from them for fear of a spirit of desertion. Blank And when

these have become /a community/ in Israel

13 /in compliance with these arrangements/ **they are to be segregated from within the dwelling of the men of sin to walk to the desert in order to open there** His path.

14 **As it is written (Isa 40:3):**

«In the desert, prepare the way of **, straighten in the steppe a roadway for our God».**

15 **This is the study of the law wh[i]ch he commanded through the hand of Moses**, in order to act in compliance with all that has been revealed from age to age,

16 and according to what the prophets have revealed through his holy spirit. Blank And anyone of the men of the Community, the covenant of

17 the Community, who insolently shuns anything at all commanded, cannot approach the **pure** food of the men of holiness,

18 and cannot know anything of their counsels until his deeds have been **cleansed** from every depravity, walking in perfect behaviour.”

García Martínez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J. C. (1999). [*“The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition \(translations\)”*](#). Eerdmans. 89-91.

The Kingdom of the Skies is Near!

Matthew introduces John and his message with a key phrase that will be found in Jesus’ mouth later in chapter 4. God’s Kingdom is a key theme in the Hebrew Bible. The association with the skies as the place of God’s throne is a common image in Israel’s Scriptures.

Psalm 103:19 Instructor's Translation

The LORD has established **his throne in the skies**, and **his kingdom** rules over all.

Psalm 145:10-13 NASB

¹⁰ All your works shall give thanks to you, O LORD, and your godly ones shall bless you.

¹¹ They shall speak of **the glory of your kingdom** and talk of your power;

¹² to make known to the sons of men your mighty acts and the glory of the majesty of **your kingdom**.

¹³ **Your kingdom** is an **everlasting kingdom**, and your dominion endures throughout all generations.

Daniel 4:2-3 NASB

² It has seemed good to me to declare the signs and wonders which the Most High God has done for me. ³ How great are his signs and how mighty are his wonders! **His kingdom** is an **everlasting kingdom** and his dominion is from generation to generation.

Daniel 4:34 NASB

But at the end of that period, I, Nebuchadnezzar, raised my eyes toward heaven and my reason returned to me, and I blessed the Most High and praised and honored him who lives forever; for **his dominion is an everlasting dominion ...**

Note that “kingdom of the skies” here does not refer to a place where people go after they die. Rather, it describes the royal presence and will of God that has come down from Heaven to make itself felt here on Earth.

The idea of God's heavenly reign becoming realized on earth is what Daniel 7 is all about.

Daniel 7:13-14 NASB

¹³ I kept looking in the night visions,
and behold, with the clouds of heaven
one like a Son of Man was coming,
and he came up to the Ancient of Days
and was presented before him.

¹⁴ And to **him was given dominion** (שלטן),
glory and **a kingdom** (מלכו),
that all the peoples, nations and men of every language
might serve him.
His dominion is an everlasting dominion
which will not pass away;
and **his kingdom** is one
which will not be destroyed.

Daniel 7:18 Instructor's Translation

But the saints of the Highest One will receive **the kingdom**
and possess **the kingdom** forever, for all ages to come.

Daniel 7:27 NASB

Then the sovereignty, the dominion and the greatness of all the kingdoms under the whole heaven
will be given to the people of the saints of the Highest One;
his kingdom will be an everlasting kingdom, and all the dominions will serve and obey him.

By making John the announcer of the arrival of Heaven's Kingdom, Matthew draws a straight line from John to Jesus to the disciples and the announcement of the apostles.

Matthew 3:1-2 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now, in those days Ioannes the immerser arrived,
announcing in the wilderness of Ioudaia,

² saying, "**Change direction!**
Because **the kingdom of the skies has come near!**"

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began to announce and say,
"**Change direction!**
Because **the kingdom of the skies has come near!**"

Matthew 10:5-7 Instructor's Translation

⁵ These the twelve Iesous sent,
having instructed them, saying,
"Onto the road of the nations you will not depart,

and into a city of the Samaritans you will not enter,
⁶ but rather go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel,
⁷ and as you go, announce, saying,
'The kingdom of the skies has come near!'"

Just as John's announcement is for all Israel, Jesus and the apostles announce their message to all of the "lost sheep of Israel" (see [Matt. 10:6](#) and [15:24](#)).

Immersion, Repentance, and Confession of Sin

In the Hebrew Bible, ritual washing was required of the priests and Levites before approaching God's presence in the temple (see [Lev. 16:4, 24](#)), and it was also required of Israelites who had completed a ritual of purification and had renewed access to the temple courtyard (see [Lev. 12-15](#)).

Within the Hebrew Bible, this ritual immersion is itself linked to the de-creation and re-creation theme that is developed within the Torah and Prophets, where passage through the water and/or fire is an image of judgment, divine mercy, and purification.

- [Genesis 1](#): The dry land is delivered from the waters and established as an Eden outpost.
- [Genesis 6-9](#): Noah and his family are delivered through the de-creation waters into a new Eden.
- [Genesis 19](#): Lot and his family are delivered through the de-creation fire.
- [Exodus 14-15](#): Moses leads Israel through the waters and to Mount Sinai for a covenant ceremony.

In the Second Temple period, Israelites began to extend this symbolism so that individuals might go through a ritual immersion as a symbol of repentance and renewal of commitment to God.

- The *Sibyllene Oracles* 4.165 say: "Wash your bodies in rivers, stretch out your hands to heaven for forgiveness ..."
- Josephus describes the Essenes (likely the same group at Qumran connected to the Dead Sea Scrolls) this way: "After which they assemble themselves together again into one place; and when they have clothed themselves in white veils, they then bathe their bodies in cold water. And after this purification is over ..." (*Jewish War* 2.8.4, sec. 129).
- Josephus also describes John: "John, who was called the Baptist; for Herod slew him, who was a good man, and commanded the Jews to exercise virtue, both as to righteousness towards one another, and piety towards God, and so to come to baptism; for that the washing would be acceptable to him, if they made use of it, not in order to the putting away of some sins only, but for the purification of the body; supposing still that the soul was thoroughly purified beforehand by righteousness" (*Jewish Antiquities*, 18.116-118).

Fire, Fruit, and Immersion in the Spirit

John's Audience

Notice that Matthew specifies the two groups that elicit John's anger, the Phariseans and Sadduceans. These two groups represent the most powerful and enduring covenant institutions in Israel's culture.

- Pharisaians = guardians and teachers of Torah and the covenant
- Saddoukaians = priests and facilitators of Israel's worship in the temple

John's message in [Matthew 3:7-12](#) is itself a collage of hyperlinked texts from the Hebrew Bible that focus on the compromised status of Israel among the nations.

- "seed of snakes": [Genesis 3:15](#)
- "make good fruit": [Genesis 2-3](#)
- seed-fruit-children of Abraham: [Genesis 12, 15, 17](#)
- Israel as a compromised tree producing bad fruit: [Isaiah 5:1-7](#), [Micah 7:1-6](#)
- The day of divine justice as a threshing floor where wheat and chaff are separated: [Psalm 1](#)
- A day of Yahweh's anger coming upon Israel for violating their covenant commitment: [Malachi 3-4](#)

Malachi 3:1-3 NASB

¹ "Behold, I am going to send **my messenger**, and **he will prepare the way before me**.

And the Lord, whom you seek,

he will suddenly come to his temple;

and the messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight, behold, he is coming,"

says the LORD of hosts.

² "But **who can endure the day of his coming?**

And who can stand when he appears?

For **he is like a refiner's fire** and like fullers' soap.

³ He will sit as a smelter and purifier of silver,

and he will purify **the sons of Levi** and refine them like gold and silver,

so that they may present to the LORD offerings in righteousness."

Malachi 4:4-6 NASB

⁴ Remember the law of Moses My servant,

even the statutes and ordinances

which I commanded him in Horeb for all Israel.

⁵ Behold, I am going to send you **Elijah the prophet**
before **the coming of the great and terrible day of the Lord**.

⁶ **He will change the direction/restore (Heb. *shuv* / שוב) the hearts** of the fathers to their children
and the hearts of the children to their fathers,
so that I will not come and smite the land with a curse.

All these texts describe a coming act of purifying divine justice upon Israel, akin to the warnings of Israel's prophets. But notice how the outer frames of John's speech ([v. 7b-10](#) and [12](#)) both speak of a separation between the good and bad trees, and the wheat and the chaff. The central panel speaks of that separation in yet another way.

- John's water baptism is about the washing away and "death" of Israel's sins as they pass through the waters.
- The Messiah's baptism will bring a purifying fire to Israel (as in [Mal. 3-4](#)), which will also separate between the faithful and unfaithful within Israel. Here, John brings together two important framing texts

from Isaiah 1-4.

Isaiah 1:27-31 NASB

²⁷ Zion will be redeemed with justice
and her **repentant ones** with righteousness.

²⁸ But transgressors and sinners will be crushed together,
and those who forsake the Lord will come to an end.

²⁹ Surely you will be ashamed of **the oaks** which you have desired,
and you will be embarrassed at **the gardens** which you have chosen.

³⁰ For you will be like **an oak** whose leaf fades away
or as **a garden** that has no water.

³¹ The strong man will become tinder, his work also a spark.
Thus they shall both **burn together**
and there will be **none to extinguish them**.

Isaiah 4:2-4 NASB

² In that day the Branch of the LORD will be beautiful and glorious, and the fruit of the earth will be the pride and the adornment of the survivors of Israel. ³ It will come about that he who is left in Zion and remains in Jerusalem will be called holy—everyone who is recorded for life in Jerusalem. ⁴ When the LORD has **washed away the filth** of the daughters of Zion and **rinsed the bloodshed of Jerusalem** from her midst, **by the spirit of judgment and the spirit of burning**,

John's message announces the arrival of the "Branch of the Lord" who will bring a great "burning fire" that will purify Israel. Some will be consumed, others will endure. It all depends on how they respond.

This means that the "spirit" and "fire" of John's announcement could refer to:

1. spirit = [positive] Christian baptism (as in 28:19-20) and fire = [negative] judgment on Jerusalem (as in 25:41)
2. spirit [negative] and fire [negative] both refer to the coming purifying judgment on Jerusalem

Fulfilling All Righteousness

¹³ Then Jesus arrived from Galilias at **the Jordanes**,
to **loannes**, to be **immersed** by him,

a ¹⁴ but **loannes prevented him**,

b saying,
"I need to **immersed** by you,
and you would come to me?!"

b' 15 But responding Jesus said to him,
 “Allow it now!
 For this is what’s appropriate for us,
 in order to **fill-full** all doing-right.”

a' **Then he allowed him.**

16 And, after being **immersed**,
Jesus immediately came up from **the water**,
and look, **the skies** were opened for him,
and he saw the **spirit of God** coming down like a dove,
and coming upon him,
17 and look, a voice from **the skies** was speaking,
 “This is **my son**,
 the beloved one,
 in him I have delight.”

Matthew 3:13-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

Matthew 3:14-15 is an episode unique to Matthew among the Gospels. Matthew’s account addresses a problem raised by the fact that Jesus was immersed by John, when Jesus had nothing to “repent” from and was in fact John’s superior (which John himself recognizes).

This episode brings us close to the heart of Matthew’s claims about Jesus’ identity.

- “Righteousness” in Matthew is about Israel’s obligation to do right by God and neighbor in covenant communal relationships. This is consistently what righteousness means in Matthew (see Matt. 5:6, 10:20; 6:1, 33).
- “Fulfilling” (Grk. *pleroo*) in Matthew has to do with how Jesus as Israel’s Messiah takes up what was unfinished and unresolved in Israel’s story and carries it to completion.
 - “fulfill” in the Scriptural quotes in Matthew 1-4 and 26-28
 - “fulfilling” the Torah in Matthew 5:17-21

Jesus “fulfills all doing-what-is-right” by identifying himself, as the divine Son, with Israel’s long history of suffering and death that resulted from their sins. Jesus enters into the “death-waters” in solidarity with his people, trusting that the Father will deliver him into Eden-life out the other side.

“As the son of God, [Jesus] is bound to the will of the Father, so that his divine sonship is manifest in his obedience to God. In the passion this leads to his not making use of his power to save himself from his enemies. So too in the baptism, Jesus lays his superior status aside and subordinates himself to the will of the Father, in that he allows his rightful exalted status as Son of God to remain hidden in his human existence, and goes the earthly way assigned to him by God ... Jesus places himself in solidarity with the people by responding to the Baptist’s message the way Israel should respond, seeing that John came ‘in the way of righteousness’ (Matt. 21:32).”

The Apocalypse of Jesus

This short story is of momentous significance for Matthew's presentation of Jesus as both Israel's messianic deliverer and the divine glory of God become human. Matthew has taken up Mark's shorter presentation of this story and adapted a number of key words to make even more clear the Hebrew Bible echoes he wants us to hear.

Mark 1:10-11 Insutruactor's Translation

¹⁰ Immediately coming up out of the water, he saw the heavens being torn, and the Spirit like a dove descending unto him; ¹¹ and a voice came out of the heavens: "You are my beloved Son, in you I am well-pleased."

Matthew 3:16-17 NASB

¹⁶ After being baptized, Jesus came up immediately from the water; and behold, the heavens were opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming on him, ¹⁷ and behold, a voice out of the heavens said, "This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well-pleased."

Luke 3:21-22 NASB

²¹ Now when all the people were baptized, Jesus was also baptized, and while he was praying, heaven was opened, ²² and the Holy Spirit descended upon him in bodily form like a dove, and a voice came out of heaven, "You are my beloved Son, in you I am well-pleased."

Matthew has shifted the object of Jesus' seeing from Mark's "he saw the heavens opening and the Spirit ..." to focus Jesus' sight on seeing the Spirit as a dove, while the opening remains the scenic backdrop.

The imagery of the "opening of the heavens" is a key signal from Matthew that this narrative is an apocalypse, a moment where the veil between Heaven and Earth is opened (see also [Ezek. 1:1](#); [Acts 10:11](#); [Rev. 4:1](#), [19:11](#)).

Echoes of an Apocalypse

Matthew has received an earlier tradition about Jesus' baptism and lightly reshapes it in order to highlight a few features of the story. The main way the gospel authors help the reader see the meaning and significance of this story is by adopting specific words and imagery from important texts in the Hebrew Scriptures. By meditating on these echoes of Scripture, we can see what the gospels want us find here in this story.

Echo 1: Genesis, the Watery Cosmic Apocalypse

The cosmic water and bird imagery comes directly from Genesis 1:2, where God's Spirit is depicted as a bird hovering over the chaotic pre-creation waters. The Spirit of God's presence over the waters signals the transition from pre-creation chaos to the process of God's creative work by speaking his word.

Genesis 1:2-3 Instructor's Translation

2 Now, the land was wild and waste, and darkness was over the face of the abyss-waters,³ and the Spirit of Elohim was fluttering over the face of the waters, and God said, "Let there be light ..."

Genesis 8:8, 10, 12 Instructor's Translation

⁸ And he sent out a dove to see whether the waters had subsided from upon the face of the ground. ...

¹⁰ And he waited another seven days, and again he sent out the dove from the ark. ...

¹² And he waited seven more days, and he sent out the dove. But it did not return again to him.

The point: By echoing Genesis 1, Matthew is signalling that God is bringing about a new-creation act of cosmic importance. It will involve a reordering of creation on a scale similar to creation itself. By linking to the image of a dove, the story shows that the fluttering dove is a sign of re-creation after the long devastation of Israel's slavery to the nations.

"Jesus, the evangelists, and the early church utilized the dove, resonating within the denouement of Noah's story, to construe Jesus' baptism as the end of judgment, the reversal of exile, the new creation, and the opportunity to herald the good news of God's presence and Kingdom."

Capes, David. (1999). "Intertextual Echoes in the Matthean Baptismal Narrative," [*Bulletin for Biblical Research* vol. 9](#). 47.

Echo 2: The Open Heavens and the Resting Spirit

Isaiah 11:1-2 NASB

¹ Then a shoot will spring from the stem of Jesse,
and a branch from his roots will bear fruit.

² **The Spirit of Yahweh will rest on him,**
the spirit of wisdom and understanding,
the spirit of counsel and strength,
the spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord.

Isaiah 64:1 Instructor's Translation

Oh that you would **rip open the skies** and **come down** ...

Isaiah 11 and 64 both speak of future longing and hope for Israelites living under imperial occupation. Their hope was for a coming messianic deliverer from the lineage of King David (Isa. 11) who would be empowered by God's Spirit to bring justice and peace to the nations. And when the violent oppression of the nations seemed to be too much, the longing of God's people would erupt in cries for help (Isa. 64) that God would part the skies and come down.

Matthew wants us to see that Jesus' baptism is a transition moment in history, the moment when God "came down" in the form of the Father sending the Son and then sending the Spirit to empower the Son for his mission.

Echo 3: Ezekiel's Vision

Ezekiel 1:1 NASB

Now it came about in the thirtieth year, on the fifth day of the fourth month, while I was **by the river** Chebar among the exiles, **the heavens were opened** and **I saw visions of God**.

Ezekiel 2:2-3 LEB

² And **the Spirit came into me** as **he was speaking** to me, and it set me on my feet, and I heard **the one speaking** to me. ³ And he said to me, “**Son of adam**, I am sending you to the Israelites, to nations who are rebelling, who rebelled against me, they and their ancestors they transgressed against me until this very day.”

These passages in Ezekiel come from the prophet’s opening vision and call from God. Ezekiel was by a river in Babylon, and he described the divine presence as God’s Spirit who was sending him to a rebellious Israel. These are all relevant themes for Matthew’s presentation of Jesus, who also called himself the "Son of man" (i.e., Adam) sent to a rebellious Israel with a message of judgment and hope.

The Voice of the Father

	Mentioned in Genesis	Mentioned in the Rest of the Torah (Exodus- Deuteronomy)	The Prophets	The Writings	TaNaK as a Whole	New Testament
Abram	59x	0x	0x	2x		
Abraham	133x	18x	11x	13x		
	Total: 192x	Total: 18x	Total: 11x	Total: 15x	Total: 236x	Total: 73x
Jacob	180x	32x	98x	39x		
Israel	43x	544x	1,487x	432x		
	Total: 223x	Total: 576x	Total: 1,585x	Total: 471x	Total: 2,855x	Total: 27x

Yaaqov in Genesis and Hebrew Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The divine voice of the Father is a blend of three important moments from the Hebrew Bible, where the focus is on a divinely chosen figure who is pivotal for God's purposes.

- The Psalms son of David: This calls up the promise of Genesis 3:15 about the seed of the woman who will crush the head of the snake, which leads all the way through Abraham and Judah to the line of David. Key texts here are 2 Samuel 7 and 1 Chronicles 17.
- The Genesis 22 beloved son of the father: This calls up the story of Abraham and Sarah's successes and failures in trusting God to provide them a son. Because of their sins against Hagar and Ishmael, God requests the life of the promised son, only to provide a substitute and give the beloved son back to his family as a gift.
- The Isaiah 42 servant of Yahweh: This figure is a composite character in Isaiah who is presented as a king, a prophet, and a priestly actor who will represent Israel's covenant before God and carry out his purpose to the nations.

The Seed of the Trinity

Notice how the baptism story presents the arrival of Israel's God (as John the Immerser announced) in a threefold manner: **The Father** communicates his love for **the Son** through the presence of **the Spirit**.

Readers of Matthew have long noticed that this implicit portrait of Israel's God as three-and-one is made explicit in the final paragraph of the Gospel, as Jesus invites his future apprentices to undergo a similar immersion and re-creation in baptism.

Matthew 28:18-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ And approaching, Jesus said to them,
"All authority in the sky and on the land has been given to me,
¹⁹ so then, when y'all go, make apprentices of all the nations,
immersing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
²⁰ teaching them to keep everything that I have commanded y'all;
and look, I am with y'all all of the days,
until the conclusion of the age."

Reflection Question

What three Hebrew Bible figures are called to mind when the voice from heaven proclaims, "This is my son, the beloved one, in him I have delight" (Matt. 3:17)?